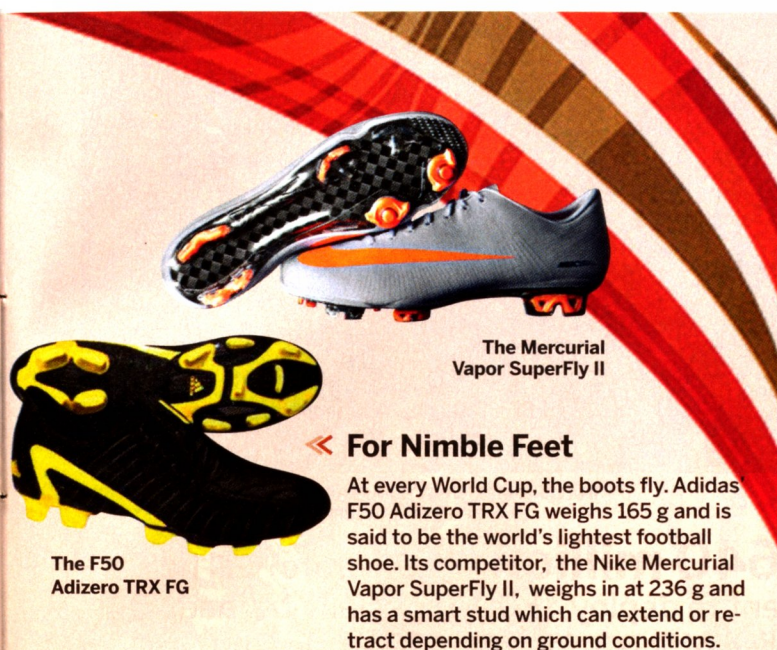




The Mercurial Vapor SuperFly II

« For Nimble Feet

At every World Cup, the boots fly. Adidas F50 Adizero TRX FG weighs 165 g and is said to be the world's lightest football shoe. Its competitor, the Nike Mercurial Vapor SuperFly II, weighs in at 236 g and has a smart stud which can extend or retract depending on ground conditions.

The F50 Adizero TRX FG

THE POSSIBILITIES

Our predictions on how the World Cup could go

ROUND 16		WINNER
A1 France v B2 Nigeria		France
C1 England v D2 Ghana/Serbia		England
D1 Germany v C2 USA		Germany
B1 Argentina v A2 South Africa/Uruguay		Argentina
E1 Netherlands v F2 Paraguay/Slovakia		Netherlands
G1 Brazil v H2 Chile		Brazil
F1 Italy v E2 Denmark		Italy
H1 Spain v G2 Portugal		Spain

QUARTERFINALS		WINNER
Netherlands v Brazil		Brazil
France v England		England
Argentina v Germany		Germany
Italy v Spain		Spain

SEMIFINALS		FINAL: Brazil v Spain
England v Brazil / Germany v Spain		WINNER: Spain

ODDS ON TOP GOALSCORERS*

David Villa	8/1
Lionel Messi	9/1
Wayne Rooney	9/1
Luis Fabiano	12/1
Fernando Torres	12/1
Robin van Persie	14/1
Cristiano Ronaldo	16/1
Gonzalo Higuain	16/1
Didier Drogba	25/1
Diego Milito	25/1
Miroslav Klose	33/1
Carlos Tevez	33/1

« The eco-friendly jersey

Nine teams will be wearing Nike 'Considered' jerseys, made from recycled plastic bottles. These plastic bottles, sourced from Japanese and Taiwanese landfill sites, were melted to produce the polyester yarn that makes the shirt. One shirt is made up of eight discarded bottles.

Football, a predominantly 'black sport' in South Africa, has been embraced by every race in the Rainbow Nation, with even previously sceptical observers throwing their weight behind the event. Recently, the Blue Bulls—South Africa's standout rugby side—chose to host two of their most crucial matches in Soweto, a previous hotbed for racial tensions and the symbolic home of black struggle in the country.

The Bulls, from the Afrikaner-dominated Pretoria, shattered boundaries with one inspired move, and their subsequent winning of the Super 14 tournament in the heart of Soweto was another step towards unifying a nation that is still rebuilding itself.

The sight of white Bulls' fans mixing with locals in taverns and in the stands has galvanised the wave of support behind 'Bafana Bafana' for this World Cup, in much the same way that the 1995 Rugby World Cup swept up the entire nation and pushed the unfancied Springboks all the way to the world title.

Yet, a similar fairy-tale story for South Africa's national team is not likely. Most fans' hopes are now consigned to simply qualifying for the second round. The embarrassment of becoming the first host nation to fall at the first hurdle is a prospect that no one wants to even consider. Form though suggests that captain Aaron Mokoena's side will have to find new levels to emerge from the group with France, Uruguay and Mexico.

Indeed, 'Bafana Bafana' have declined since the turn of the century and the entire country is now in silent prayer that the five-month training camp before the tournament will reap rewards for coach Carlos Alberto Parreira. This is the Brazilian's second stint at the helm and his presence has managed to restore some sort of stability to a ship that was threatening to veer dangerously off-course.

After a short break, Parreira's return as an emergency measure immediately transformed the fortunes with an unbeaten, 10-match run up to the World Cup. Infrastructure may have taken shape but informed observers are nagged with worry about the South Africa's overall footballing fortunes.

Since being on the brink of making